

Airline Refund Cheat-Sheet — Cash, Not a Voucher

Since the U.S. DOT's 2024 automatic-refund rule (in force 2026), airlines must refund you in **CASH to your original payment method — not a voucher** — in these situations. Print it and keep it in your travel folder.

✓ When you're owed your fare back

When the airline **cancels** or **"significantly changes"** your flight **and you decline the rebooking**, you're owed your fare back (plus taxes & fees). A "significant change" includes:

- ☐ Departure/arrival time moves **more than 3 hours (domestic)** or **more than 6 hours (international)**
- ☐ Your departure or arrival **airport changes**
- ☐ They **add a connection or stop** that wasn't there
- ☐ You're **downgraded** to a lower class of service
- ☐ **(Disability)** a plane swap to a **less accessible** aircraft

✓ Other money they owe you

- ☐ **Late checked bag** — refund of the bag fee if it's not delivered within **12 hours (domestic)** or **15–30 hours (international)**. *You must file a mishandled-baggage report at the airport.*
- ☐ **A paid extra you didn't get** — Wi-Fi, seat selection / extra legroom, or in-flight entertainment that didn't work → refund of that fee.

How fast they must pay

PAID BY CREDIT CARD

7 business days

ANY OTHER PAYMENT

20 calendar days

The exact words to use

Say or write this to the airline:

"My flight was [canceled / changed by more than 3 hours / my bag arrived more than 12 hours late]. Under the DOT's automatic-refund rule, I'm requesting a full refund to my original payment method — not a voucher. Please confirm the refund and the timeframe."

If they stall — escalate (free)

1. **Ask in writing** and reference "the DOT automatic-refund rule."
2. **File a free DOT complaint:** [transportation.gov/airconsumer](https://www.transportation.gov/airconsumer)
3. **Paid by card?** You can also dispute the charge with your card issuer.

▲ **Heads up:** these are U.S. DOT rules. **Flying to or from the EU or UK?** A long delay there can pay up to €600 per passenger (EU261/UK261). Free check: moneyyoureowed.com/go/airhelp (AirHelp affiliate link: we may earn a commission; they charge only if you win.)

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General educational information, not legal advice. Based on the U.S. DOT refund rule in effect as of 2026; rules can change — confirm current details at [transportation.gov/airconsumer](https://www.transportation.gov/airconsumer).